

Respect Yourself and Others: Respect and Accountability, Featuring Doug Buce

Doug Buce, President, CLO, Boing Dynamics, Inc.

You know a team is great when all the players respect each other, have good chemistry, and everyone pulls their own weight. Under these conditions, collaboration is healthy and productive, everyone is positive, everyone is fully dedicated, and team success is measured more by “we go” versus ego.

Let’s face it. There will be times when certain people that are respected don’t make great team members. They make mistakes. They aren’t fully dedicated. They undermine the work of others. How do you handle that? Well, most team members expect the team leader to step in and fix the problem. And that is understandable because that’s the default approach. That approach is called power-based accountability where the leader forces accountability.

In Patrick Lencioni’s book, *The Five Dysfunctions of a Team*, he talks about the best form of accountability—peer-to-peer accountability, where individuals hold each other accountable for results. If you see me doing something that is detrimental to the team goal, you talk with me about it. You see the best sports teams do this all the time. Somebody misses an assignment and a team member immediately gets in their face. Now, it may be a bit awkward and unprofessional to get into each other’s faces in the workplace, but there is a right way to do it—and a need to do it.

Three things have to be in place for peer-to-peer accountability to work. The first is trust. We need to have honest trust for the team, not artificial harmony where the team pretends that things are good. We need to be able to trust each other and know that what we share will not be used against us at a later time.

The second is our ability to engage in healthy debate. We can, in a healthy way, debate conflicting views on how to approach work challenges.

And the third thing is commitment. If all of us on the team have a clear vision of the goals and we buy in to the approach because we’ve had a chance to weigh in on the decision, we can commit.

Those three things—authentic trust, healthy debate, and commitment—provide the foundation to have peer-to-peer accountability discussions.

Pat created trust of her staff and players by being consistent, always keeping her word, and getting to know her players and staff on a personal level. Pat also had no problem engaging in healthy debate. Her assistant coaches were never “yes” people. They were always empowered to disagree with Pat and offer an alternative viewpoint. And there is no doubt Pat was 100 percent committed to her teams and their goals.

Pat's mastery of peer-to-peer accountability was one reason for her extraordinary success.

Do you create an environment of trust, healthy debate, and commitment? Are you leveraging peer-to-peer accountability on your team?